



TARDIGRADE

Kingdom: Animals

The tiniest animals are even smaller than some single-celled microbes. The tardigrade uses clawed feet to clamber through forests of mosses and has a tubelike mouth for sucking up the juices of other creatures.

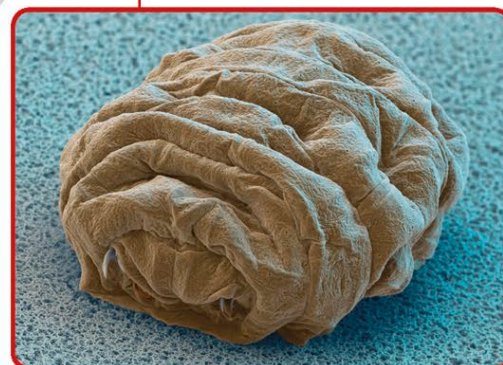


Deadly jaws

The tardigrade has needle-sharp mouthparts around the opening of its feeding tube—to pierce the cells of its prey.

Shriveled survivor

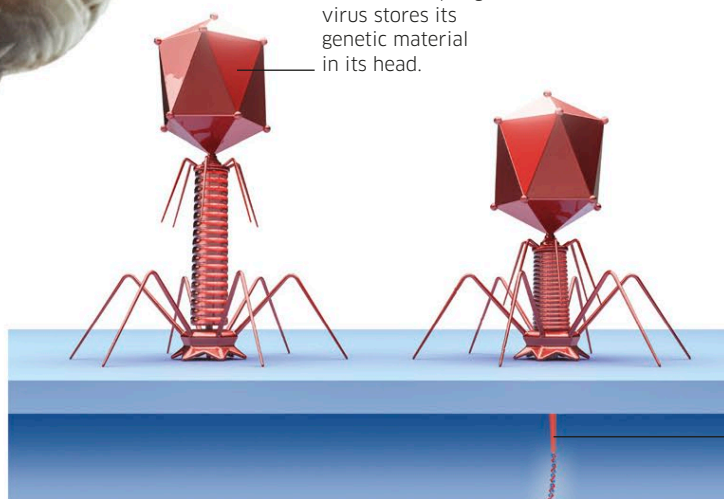
By losing 99 percent of their water and shutting down their bodily functions, tardigrades can curl up into dry husks. In this state, they can endure the harshest conditions—even being sent into space.



Stumpy legs

The way a tardigrade lumbers along on thick legs has earned it the popular name of “water bear.”

This bacteriophage virus stores its genetic material in its head.



Viruses

These are the tiniest microbes of all, but they are not true living organisms because they are not made up of cells of their own. Each virus is just an encased bundle of genetic material that invades the living cells of other organisms. It then uses the host cells to reproduce itself.

The virus's sharp spikes pierce the wall of a bacterium and inject the DNA inside.